

AMAZON TERMINATED ITS recruiting tool in 2018 after it was found to show a bias against women. So, why did the artificial intelligence (AI) tool not like women candidates? When the engineers dug into it, they found that the AI was trained using data from a time when the tech industry was dominated by men. And in doing so, the AI had 'learnt' that male candidates were preferable. Not only that, its machine learning (ML) model had learnt to penalise resumes with words like "women's" as in "women's chess club". And that was the reason why it recommended only male candidates.

While Amazon stopped using the tool once the issue came to light, it has become a prime example of how not to deploy AI systems. But even five years later, the relevance of this incident has only grown. Sample this: per Accenture's 2022 Tech Vision Research report, only 35 per cent of users globally trust how AI is implemented across companies. And about 77 per cent believe that companies must be held responsible for any misuse of AI.

And while big tech companies have more experience working with developing and potentially harmful tech, the responsible use of AI within the Indian start-up ecosystem poses a big question too.

For context, India's start-up ecosystem is the third largest after the US and China. Per estimates by Nasscom and consultancy Zinnov, there were about 3,000 tech start-ups in India in 2021, with the maximum number from the field of AI (1,900).

But are tech start-ups aware of the responsibility they bear when it comes to deploying AI/ML? Inculcating the values of Responsible AI (RAI) from the beginning is important, say experts. "Sometimes, early-stage start-ups don't necessarily pay heed to compliance because they have so much to do," says Srinivas Rao Mahankali, CEO of start-up innovation centre T-Hub, adding that any such omission may come back to bite them later.

Conversations around RAI don't happen at the early stages, says an investor who has invested in many start-ups, on condition of anonymity. A lot of times, founders are aware of the pitfalls of such tech being misused, but they are inadequately equipped to avoid them, says the investor. Stakeholders also point out that while there is knowledge of such matters at

the executive level, it needs to trickle down the corporate pyramid to avoid their harmful effects in real-life situations. But then, how does one get started?

THE INTELLIGENCE IMPACT

Let us start with the basics. What is RAI? Professional services firm Accenture defines it as the practice of designing and deploying AI with good intentions—to empower employees and businesses and fairly impact customers—and scale AI with confidence and trust.

Also called trustworthy or ethical AI, RAI has many applications. For example, in India, RAI's use can be found in retail preferences, inventory management, cybersecurity, healthcare, banking, etc.

"In healthcare, AI is used to provide insights for medical diagnosis, and identify complex health patterns. In such cases, safety, bias and explainability (the concept that an AI/ML model and its output can be explained in a way that "makes sense" to a human being) are major concerns. In banking, AI is deployed to detect fraud and analyse user behaviour. This too raises fairness and privacy issues," says Sachin Lodha, Chief Scientist at TCS Research.

These use cases reveal that RAI affects not just enterprises, but society at large, especially the end users. Directly or indirectly, AI has the power to reshape resource allocation and policy decisions, among other things. Therefore, it is imperative to assess how they can be made more transparent, fair, accurate, risk-free and free of biases.

Some simple steps that companies can take to build RAI include awareness around capacity building, assessing impacts, creating prototypes and testing it on various metrics like behavioural patterns, fairness, explainability, and more. And then working to filter out the biased patterns that are observed. Simply put, RAI is about designing systems that condense what has happened to identify issues that can arise and then take proactive steps to eliminate them. However, one step that start-ups need to be careful about is the usage of data in their models.

Typically, an AI is fed a lot of data, and it calculates based on that, says Achyut Chandra, Manager and Lead of HCL's Open Innovation. That's why, he says, being specific is vital. "Considering the feature we are capturing from the data sets is very important," he adds.



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